

Artificial Intelligence Action Plan Comments on AI Literacy, Workforce Development, STEM Education and Talent Pipeline, Includes Revision Comments for OMB Memoranda M-24-10 and M-24-18, in Response to Presidential Executive Order 14179 Issued January 23, 2025

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Comments - Artificial Intelligence Literacy Action Plan

This plan incorporates recommendations from the NSCAI Final Report, emphasizing STEM education, digital skills, and addressing the AT talent competition.

Guiding Principle:

This AI Literacy Action Plan is designed to provide resources and support to federal agencies, state and local education agencies, and other stakeholders in developing and implementing AI literacy initiatives tailored to specific needs and contexts. It acknowledges the importance of a strong federal role in promoting nationwide AI education, workforce development, and a robust national AI talent pipeline.

Objectives:

1. **Establish a National Foundation for AI Literacy:** Develop a national framework, promote STEM education, and prioritize digital skills to prepare a workforce for the AI era.
2. **Cultivate AI Talent through Education and Training:** Reform the education system, support faculty development, and create partnerships to increase the quantity and quality of AI professionals.
3. **Develop a Robust AI Workforce:** Train diverse groups-Researchers, Implementers, End Users, and Informed Consumers-to ensure comprehensive AI literacy and expertise across society.
4. **Attract and Retain AI Talent:** Implement strategies to attract and retain top AI talent, both domestic and international, to maintain U.S. leadership in AI.

5. **Ensure Continuous Improvement and Adaptation:** Establish mechanisms for ongoing evaluation, adaptation, and collaboration to maintain a cutting-edge AI education ecosystem.

Implementation Strategies:

1. **National Coordination and Leadership:** A National AI Education and Workforce Development Council, led by OSTP, will coordinate efforts across federal agencies, states, and stakeholders.

2. **Data Collection and Evaluation:** Implement systems to track AI education and workforce development outcomes.

3. **Public Engagement and Outreach:** Launch a national campaign to promote AI literacy and the importance of AI education.

Key Stakeholders:

Federal Agencies (OSTP, NSF, NIST, DOL, etc.)

State and Local Education Agencies

Higher Education Institutions

Businesses and Industry Partners

Non-profit Organizations

Artificial Intelligence Literacy Action Plan

Short-Term Initiatives (1-4 years)

Directive 1: Create a National AI Extension Service

"Within 180 days, the Chief AI Officers (CAIOs) of relevant agencies, in collaboration with the Office of Personnel Management (OPM), shall establish a framework for a National AI Extension Service, modeled after agricultural extension programs. This framework shall include:

A plan for deploying AI experts to underserved regions, with specific criteria for identifying these regions based on factors such as current AI workforce concentration, economic need, and potential for AI impact.

A strategy for recruiting AI experts from academia, industry, and government, including incentives such as temporary assignments, fellowships, and competitive pay.

A methodology for matching AI experts with the specific needs of local communities and organizations, focusing on sectors such as healthcare, education, and small business.

A system for tracking and evaluating the impact of the AI Extension Service on AI literacy and economic development in underserved regions, with regular reports submitted to OMB."

Directive 2: Establish Regional AI Resource Centers

"Within 1 year, the National Science Foundation (NSF), in partnership with other relevant agencies, shall fund and establish Regional AI Resource Centers. These centers shall:

Be strategically located to serve as intermediaries between major research hubs and local communities, with a goal of establishing at least one center in each of the ten federal regions within the first 4 years.

Provide access to AI training, tools, and resources for local governments, businesses, and educational institutions.

Facilitate collaboration between AI experts and local stakeholders, including workshops, seminars, and hackathons.

Develop and maintain a database of AI experts and resources available in the region.

Establish metrics for evaluating the effectiveness of the centers in promoting AI literacy and regional development, with regular reports submitted to NSF and OMB."

Directive 3: Develop Standardized AI Literacy Curricula

"Within 180 days, the Department of Education (or a designated lead agency), in collaboration with the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) and other relevant agencies, shall develop standardized AI literacy curricula for various educational levels and professional sectors. These curricula shall:

Include modules on the basics of AI, its capabilities, limitations, and ethical implications, suitable for integration into existing K-12 and higher education programs.

Develop specialized curricula for different sectors, such as healthcare, finance, manufacturing, and government services, focusing on the application of AI within those sectors.

Be designed for rapid deployment through existing educational institutions, including schools, colleges, universities, and vocational training centers.

Incorporate regular updates to the curricula to reflect the latest advancements in AI.

Establish a certification process for individuals completing the curricula, with recognized credentials for different levels of AI literacy."

NSCAI Addition:

"Curricula development should prioritize digital skills and incorporate them across all levels of education."

Directive 4: Incentivize AI Experts to Teach and Consult

"Within 90 days, relevant agencies, in collaboration with OPM, shall establish incentive programs to encourage AI experts to spend time teaching and consulting in regions currently lacking AI expertise. These programs shall include:

Fellowship programs for AI experts to spend sabbatical periods or temporary assignments at educational institutions or community organizations in underserved regions.

Grants and funding opportunities for AI experts who develop and deliver AI literacy programs in these regions.

Recognition and awards for AI experts who make significant contributions to spreading AI literacy.

A system for matching AI experts with teaching and consulting opportunities in underserved regions, including a national database of available positions and experts."

Directive 5: Launch a National STEM and Digital Skills Initiative (NDEA II)

"Within 1 year, Congress should enact and relevant agencies should begin implementation of a National Defense Education Act II, with a strong focus on STEM and digital skills. This initiative shall:

Allocate significant funding to promote STEM education at all levels, from K-12 to graduate studies.

Support programs that enhance digital literacy and provide access to technology for students and educators.

Establish national goals for increasing the number of STEM graduates and improving STEM proficiency.

Track progress toward these goals and report regularly to the public."

Medium-Term Strategies (5-10 years)

Directive 6: Support Development of AI Faculty

"Within 2 years, the NSF and the Department of Education (or a designated lead agency) shall implement programs to support the development of AI faculty at regional universities and community colleges. These programs shall:

Provide funding for new faculty positions in AI and related fields at regional universities and community colleges.

Offer scholarships and fellowships for graduate students pursuing AI education with the intention of teaching at regional institutions.

Establish grants for professional development and training for existing faculty to enhance their AI expertise.

Create a mentorship program pairing AI experts from leading research institutions with faculty at regional universities and community colleges.

Set goals for increasing the number of AI faculty at regional institutions and track progress towards these goals."

Directive 7: Create Partnerships Between AI Hotspot Institutions and Distant Institutions

"Within 3 years, the Department of Education (or a designated lead agency) and NSF shall facilitate the creation of formal partnerships between AI hotspot institutions and more distant educational institutions. These partnerships shall:

- Support joint research projects between faculty and students at partnering institutions.

- Enable the sharing of AI courses and educational resources, including online and hybrid learning options.

- Provide opportunities for students from distant institutions to participate in internships and research experiences at AI hotspot institutions.

- Establish faculty exchange programs to promote collaboration and knowledge sharing.

- Develop metrics to assess the impact of these partnerships on AI education and research capacity at participating institutions."

Directive 8: Develop Specialized AI Programs for Regional Economic Needs

"Within 4 years, the Department of Labor, in collaboration with state and local governments, shall support the development of specialized AI programs tailored to regional economic needs. These programs shall:

- Identify key industries and sectors in different regions that could benefit from AI applications.

- Develop training programs that focus on the specific AI skills and knowledge needed in those industries.

- Partner with local businesses and organizations to provide hands-on training and internships for participants.

- Offer career counseling and job placement services for graduates of specialized AI programs.

- Track employment outcomes of program graduates and adjust programs as needed to meet evolving regional needs."

Directive 9: Establish AI Research Facilities in Underserved Regions

"Within 5 years, NSF and other relevant agencies shall fund and establish AI research facilities in currently underserved regions to create new knowledge hubs. These facilities shall:

- Be strategically located to foster regional innovation and economic growth.

- Provide state-of-the-art computing resources, data sets, and research infrastructure.

- Support interdisciplinary research in AI and its applications across various fields.

- Attract top AI talent to the region through competitive funding and research opportunities.

- Measure the impact of these facilities on regional AI research output, innovation, and economic development."

Directive 10: Implement AI Training Programs for Key Archetypes

"Within 5 years, relevant agencies shall support the development and implementation of targeted AI training programs for four key archetypes:

Researchers: Programs focused on advancing AI R&D, algorithm development, and theoretical research.

Implementers: Training focused on data handling, model building, and collaboration with domain experts to deploy AI solutions.

End Users: System-specific training for professionals whose work will be augmented by AI tools, emphasizing effective utilization and human-AI collaboration.

Informed Consumers: Educational initiatives aimed at the general public to foster understanding of AI capabilities, limitations, and ethical implications, enabling informed decision-making about AI products and services."

Long-Term Initiatives (10+ years)

Directive 11: Build a National Platform for AI Continuing Education

"Within 10 years, the Department of Education (or a designated lead agency), in collaboration with NIST and other relevant agencies, shall develop and launch a national platform for AI continuing education. This platform shall:

Offer a wide range of online courses, workshops, and resources for individuals to continuously update their AI knowledge and skills.

Provide personalized learning paths based on individual needs and career goals.

Incorporate the latest advancements in AI and emerging trends.

Offer stackable credentials and certifications for completing continuing education programs.

Be regularly evaluated and updated to ensure its effectiveness and relevance."

Directive 12: Create Mechanisms for Sharing AI Expertise

"Within 10 years, relevant agencies shall establish mechanisms for sharing AI expertise between industries and regions. These mechanisms shall:

Facilitate the exchange of AI professionals between different sectors and regions through temporary assignments, fellowships, and mentorship programs.

Support the creation of industry-specific AI working groups and consortia to foster collaboration and knowledge sharing.

Develop online platforms and databases to connect AI experts with organizations seeking AI expertise.

Organize national and regional conferences, workshops, and events to promote networking and knowledge exchange.

Track and evaluate the effectiveness of these mechanisms in promoting AI expertise sharing and collaboration."

Directive 13: Develop Standards for AI Education and Certification

"Within 12 years, NIST, in collaboration with the Department of Education (or a designated lead agency) and professional organizations, shall develop national standards for AI education and certification. These standards shall:

Define the core competencies and learning outcomes for different levels of AI education.

Establish criteria for accrediting AI education programs and certifying AI professionals.

Promote consistency and quality in AI education and training across the country.

Be regularly reviewed and updated to reflect advancements in AI and evolving industry needs.

Work to harmonize U.S. standards with international efforts where appropriate."

Directive 14: Establish Frameworks for Public-Private Partnerships in AI Education

"Within 15 years, the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP), in collaboration with relevant agencies, shall establish frameworks for public-private partnerships in AI education. These frameworks shall:

Encourage collaboration between government, industry, academia, and non-profit organizations to advance AI education and workforce development.

Provide guidelines and best practices for establishing effective partnerships.

Incentivize industry investment in AI education through tax benefits, grants, and other mechanisms.

Support the development of industry-led AI training programs and apprenticeships.

Evaluate the impact of public-private partnerships on AI education and workforce development and refine frameworks as needed."

Directive 15: Implement Strategies to Attract and Retain Top AI Talent

"Ongoing, the federal government shall implement comprehensive strategies to attract and retain top AI talent, both domestic and international:

Streamline visa processes for highly skilled AI professionals and researchers.

Offer competitive compensation and benefits packages to AI professionals in government service.

Create a welcoming and inclusive environment that encourages diverse AI talent to contribute and thrive in the U.S.

Promote research collaborations and exchange programs with leading international AI institutions.

Highlight the U.S. as a global leader in AI innovation and opportunity to attract top talent."

Artificial Intelligence Talent & Workforce Development Action Plan

Summary:

This Action Plan outlines a multi-pronged strategy to enhance America's AI talent pipeline, bolster AI-related education at all levels, address critical national security considerations, and ensure equitable access to AI education and training in a decentralized environment. The recommendations draw on existing successes (e.g., CUNY BMCC's programs, ALPFA NERTS 2024, AFCEA International STEM Education Foundation) and incorporate new initiatives (e.g., Hugging Face repository, Ookla broadband access data) to accelerate the nation's development and retention of AI expertise.

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I. NATIONAL SECURITY AND RETAINING STEM TALENT

RATIONALE:

- Recent incidents, such as the case of a Chinese researcher at Boston University reportedly using federal funds for semiconductor research tied to foreign military applications, highlight the dangers of "brain drain" and underscore the strategic importance of retaining U.S.-trained STEM professionals.
- President Trump's second-term address to Congress included a promise to provide international students with a clear path to long-term employment. Fulfillment of this pledge remains critical for ensuring U.S. leadership and preventing talent loss to foreign adversaries.

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS:

1. Streamlined Visa and Work Authorization

- Expand and refine the DHS STEM OPT Extension List to ease the path for international graduates with AI-related expertise.

- Pass legislation or create executive action providing immediate Green Card routes for top AI graduates or professionals working in high-priority fields (e.g., semiconductors, large-scale model research).

2. National Security "Talent Retention" Task Force

- Establish a White House-led group-coordinated by the National Security Council and OSTP-to identify critical STEM skill sets and ensure these students have prioritized immigration options.
- Create guidelines preventing misuse of federal research funds by foreign militaries, while maintaining an open environment for legitimate collaborative research.

II. STRENGTHENING AI EDUCATION (K-12, HIGHER ED, CONTINUING ED)

RATIONALE:

- A decentralized education system and the potential abolition of the U.S. Department of Education will require flexible yet robust frameworks to ensure uniformly high-quality AI education across states-especially for rural and under-resourced districts.

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS:

1. Voluntary National AI Education Framework (Short-Term: 1 year)

- Led by OSTP, NIST, and a National AI Education Advisory Board, provide guidelines states can adopt or adapt.
- Integrate ethical AI, data privacy, and "explainable AI" concepts into curricula.

2. AI Curriculum and Training Support (Medium-Term: 1-3 years)

- Offer grants (via NSF or block grants to states) for K-12 teacher upskilling and curriculum pilot programs in AI and coding.
- Foster partnerships with organizations like AFCEA International STEM Education Foundation (led by Ret. Gen. Susan Lawrence) to develop teacher training and scholarship programs and to facilitate information sharing between military, government, industry and academia.

3. Community College and University Programs (Ongoing)

- Encourage more institutions to emulate CUNY BMCC's AI certificate and associate degree offerings in New York City, especially in underserved areas.
- Provide matching federal and state funds for lab infrastructure, faculty recruitment, and research capacity building.

4. Public Online Resources and Platforms (Short-Term: 1 year)

- Update the White House AI website (last updated in 2021) with curated educational resources, open-source datasets (e.g., Hugging Face repositories), and success stories from various states.

III. WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT, RESKILLING, AND UPSKILLING

RATIONALE:

- Rapid AI innovation requires agile workforce training. Both displaced workers and professionals seeking new opportunities need accessible, flexible programs.

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS:

1. Free or Low-Cost Upskilling Programs (Short-Term: 1 year)

- Replicate the NY State Department of Labor's free Coursera for unemployed New Yorkers model nationwide, focusing on AI/data science fundamentals.
- Provide "Learn and Earn" or apprenticeship-style programs that combine online coursework with real-world AI project work.

2. Industry-Aligned Certificates and Micro-Credentials (Medium-Term: 1-3 years)

- Collaborate with major tech firms to create recognized standards for AI skill levels.
- Incentivize small- and medium-sized businesses to host on-the-job AI training programs through tax credits and cost-sharing grants.

3. National AI Workforce Development Council (Long-Term: 3+ years)

- Establish a permanent body under OSTP to coordinate workforce policy, track industry demands, and align training investments with emerging AI trends (e.g., generative models, quantum AI).

IV. INFRASTRUCTURE, BROADBAND ACCESS, AND DIGITAL EQUITY

RATIONALE:

- High-speed internet and computing resources are vital for online AI courses, large-model training, remote work, and addressing rural-urban digital divides.

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS:

1. Broadband Expansion Utilizing Ookla Data (Short-Term: 1 year)

- Integrate Ookla broadband speed test data into a federal mapping initiative to identify underserved regions with the assistance of the Federal Geographic Data Committee.
- Collaborate with telecom providers/WISPs to expand coverage.

2. AI "Testbed" Grants for Rural and Suburban Communities (Medium-Term: 1-3 years)

- Fund small-scale data centers or HPC clusters in community colleges at rural or suburban sites to democratize access to AI compute infrastructure.
- Establish region-specific AI pilot programs leveraging local industries (e.g., agriculture tech in rural areas, manufacturing automation in suburban corridors).

V. INDUSTRY, PUBLIC-PRIVATE PARTNERSHIPS, AND CONFERENCES

RATIONALE:

- Conferences such as ALPFA NERTS 2024, featuring AI literacy initiatives by corporate leaders like Johanna Cordisco at Bank of America, show the value of networking and mentorship, particularly for underserved populations.

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS:

1. Conferencing and Professional Networks (Short-Term: 1 year)

- Offer federal grants or tax incentives for companies co-hosting regional AI conferences with strong diversity and inclusion components.
- Replicate the ALPFA NERTS model in multiple regions, encouraging local chapters and bridging connections between academia, industry, and underrepresented communities.

2. Collaboration with Open-Source Communities (Medium-Term: 1-3 years)

- Encourage adoption and contribution to open AI repositories like Hugging Face, facilitating knowledge sharing and community-driven advancements.
- Provide "federal challenge" funds for teams developing open-source AI solutions addressing national challenges (health, climate, defense, etc.).

VI. IMPLEMENTATION TIMELINE AND GOVERNANCE

1. Short-Term (Within 12 Months)

- White House OSTP updates the federal AI website; convenes an interagency working group with NIST, NSF, DHS, and the National Security Council to outline crucial steps for AI education and "brain-drain" mitigation.
- Launch national broadband mapping enhancements (with Ookla data) and initial pilot AI training expansions.
- Introduce legislation or executive actions to streamline AI-related visa processes and expand the DHS STEM OPT Extension List.

2. Medium-Term (1-3 Years)

- States begin adopting voluntary AI frameworks and rolling out teacher training.
- Industry-coordinated micro-credential programs, apprenticeship networks, and expanded "rural HPC clusters" begin full-scale operation.

- National AI Education Advisory Board publishes annual best-practice guidelines, helping states adapt curated curricula.

3. Long-Term (3+ Years)

- National AI Workforce Development Council formalizes policy oversight, measuring the impact of various programs.
- Uniform broadband access gaps significantly close, AI testbeds proliferate, and robust open-source communities flourish.
- AI degrees, certificates, and industry-approved micro-credentials become widely recognized across states, fueling a steady talent pipeline.

VII. MEASUREMENT, ACCOUNTABILITY, AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

- Data Collection and Reporting:
 - Implement a National AI Progress Monitoring System to track metrics such as job placement rates, enrollment in AI programs, diversity in AI fields, retention of international students, and broadband analytics.
 - Publish an Annual AI Workforce Progress Report by OSTP in partnership with the AI Workforce Development Council.
- Agile Policy Updates:
 - Conduct annual or biannual stakeholder roundtables to gather feedback and address new challenges (e.g., emerging AI subsectors, security threats, etc.).
 - Adjust policy levers (grants, immigration policy, regional hub priorities, etc.) based on real-time labor market data and performance outcomes.
- Oversight and Coordination:
 - OSTP and the National Security Council co-chair an Interagency AI Policy Task Force, ensuring alignment across defense, commercial, and educational spheres, while safeguarding research integrity from foreign exploitation.
 - Collaboration among federal, state, and private sectors ensures consistent adaptation of AI standards and best practices in a rapidly evolving industry.

OMB M-24-10 and M-24-18 Revision Comments

To comply with Executive Order 14179, OMB Memoranda M-24-10 and M-24-18 may need revisions that emphasize and align with the policy of sustaining and enhancing America's global AI dominance to promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security. Here are potential areas of revision:

1. Prioritizing Innovation and Reducing Barriers

For M-24-10, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall establish a process for identifying and removing internal bureaucratic hurdles that impede the development, testing, and deployment of AI solutions. This process shall include annual reviews of existing policies and procedures to ensure they do not unnecessarily delay or obstruct AI innovation."

"Agencies shall develop and implement strategies to modernize IT infrastructure to better support AI adoption. These strategies must include timelines, resource allocation plans, and performance metrics for improvement in areas such as data storage, computing capacity, and network connectivity."

"Agencies shall create or expand training programs aimed at enhancing the AI skills of their workforce. These programs should cover a range of proficiency levels, from basic AI literacy for all employees to advanced technical training for AI specialists. Agencies should track employee participation and skill development outcomes."

For M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall streamline their AI acquisition processes to accelerate the adoption of cutting-edge AI technologies. This includes reducing procurement timelines, simplifying contracting procedures, and establishing mechanisms for rapid prototyping and pilot testing of AI solutions."

"Agencies shall prioritize acquisition approaches that favor innovative AI solutions and promote competition among vendors. This includes using flexible contracting mechanisms, such as Other Transaction Authority (OTA) and prize challenges, to encourage participation from non-traditional vendors and small businesses."

2. Enhancing Collaboration and Knowledge Sharing

For M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall participate in the development and utilization of shared platforms or databases for AI resources. These platforms will serve as repositories for AI code, models, datasets, best practices, and lessons learned. Agencies shall contribute actively to these platforms and use them to inform their AI initiatives."

"OMB, in collaboration with relevant agencies, shall establish and maintain a cross-agency working group focused on AI procurement. This working group will develop and disseminate best practices, address common challenges, and promote consistency in AI acquisition across the federal government."

For M-24-10, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall actively seek partnerships with academia, industry, and international allies to advance AI innovation. This includes participating in joint research projects, sharing data and resources (where appropriate), and collaborating on the development of AI standards and best practices."

"Agencies shall engage with international standards bodies to promote the development of globally harmonized AI standards that reflect American values and priorities. This engagement should aim to ensure interoperability, promote innovation, and address ethical considerations in AI development and deployment."

3. Emphasizing Economic Competitiveness and National Security

For both M-24-10 and M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall prioritize the development and acquisition of AI applications that have the potential to significantly enhance U.S. economic competitiveness and national security. This includes considering the potential impact of AI projects on productivity, job creation, industrial growth, and defense capabilities."

For M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall ensure that AI acquisition strategies and practices actively contribute to U.S. economic competitiveness and national security objectives. This includes evaluating potential vendors and solutions based on factors such as their impact on domestic AI industries, supply chain resilience, and the protection of sensitive technologies."

4. Balancing Risk Management with Innovation

For M-24-10, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall adopt a risk-based approach to AI governance that balances the need for innovation with the imperative to mitigate risks. This approach should prioritize the identification and management of risks that could have significant negative impacts while avoiding overly prescriptive measures that stifle innovation."

"Agencies shall implement mechanisms for continuous improvement and adaptation of their AI risk management practices. This includes regularly reviewing and updating risk assessment methodologies, monitoring the effectiveness of mitigation strategies, and adapting to emerging AI risks and best practices."

5. Workforce Development and Training

For both M-24-10 and M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall develop and implement comprehensive AI workforce development and training programs. These programs should address the need to attract and retain top AI talent, provide ongoing training for federal employees at all levels, and ensure that the workforce has the skills necessary to effectively develop, deploy, and manage AI systems."

For M-24-18, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall incorporate AI workforce development and training requirements into AI acquisition contracts, where appropriate. This may include requiring vendors to provide training to agency personnel on the use, maintenance, and management of acquired AI systems."

"Agencies shall establish incentive programs to encourage federal employees to pursue AI-related training and professional development opportunities. This could include tuition reimbursement, professional certifications, and career advancement opportunities."

6. Promoting Ethical AI Development and Use

For M-24-10, add the following directives:

"Agencies shall strengthen requirements for transparency, accountability, and fairness in AI systems. This includes implementing measures to ensure that AI systems are explainable, auditable, and free from bias and discrimination."

"Agencies shall develop and implement policies and procedures to address the potential societal impacts of AI, including bias, discrimination, privacy violations, and job displacement. These policies should aim to promote human flourishing, protect civil rights, and ensure that AI benefits all members of society."

"Agencies shall prioritize the use of AI in a manner that promotes human flourishing, protects civil liberties, and upholds American values. This includes considering the ethical implications of AI applications, engaging with the public on AI issues, and promoting responsible AI development and deployment."